

Space Age Moments

From rudimentary rockets to modern launchers, from riding piggyback on the world to orbiting the moon, India has gone places

1 We Have Lift-off 1975

The first Indian satellite Aryabhata is launched by the Soviet Union from Kapustin Yar using a Kosmos—3M launch vehicle on April 19, 1975. Its aim is to provide an opportunity to conduct investigations in space sciences. It carries three experiments, one each in X-ray astronomy, solar physics and aeronomy.

2 Screening For All 1975

The Satellite Instructional Television Experiment begins on August 1, 1975, when 2,400 black and white community TV sets come alive in as many as villages in clusters across six states long before urban India experiences TV. NASA and ISRO join hands to design and implement this ambitious project.

3 Sensing it Right 1979

ISRO launches Bhaskara-1, a 444-kg experimental remote-sensing satellite for earth observations on June 7, 1979, from another Soviet Kosmos. The mission conducts earth observation experiments for applications related to hydrology and geology.

4 Stellar Honour 1979

Astronomer R.M. West discovers a main belt asteroid and names it Vainu Bappu—father of modern Indian astrophysics. His discovery of an important phenomenon in stellar chromospheres is known to researchers in astronomy as the Wilson-Bappu Effect.

5 A Launcher of Our Own 1980

On July 18, 1980, India preens with pride as it joins the exclusive club of space powers that can lob a satellite with a homemade rocket from their own soil. The second experimental Satellite Launch Vehicle (SLV-3) places the Rohini Satellite (RS-D1) in orbit almost a year after the first attempt failed in 1979. 0

6 Communication Leap 1982

India's first indigenous communication satellite, Indian National Satellite (INSAT-1A), is launched by the US Delta rocket on April 10, 1982.

7 Man in Space 1984

On April 2, 1984, the first and only Indian space traveller so far, Rakesh Sharma, is shot up into space to spend eight days aboard the Salyut 7 with two Soviet cosmonauts.

8 If At First... 1994

The Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle is launched, using solid and liquid propulsive systems alternately, on October 15, 1994, after the failure of the first attempt.

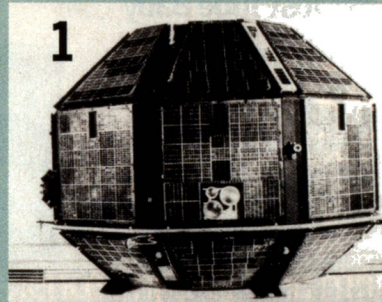
9 Tenacity Wins 2003

The second flight of the Geostationary Satellite Launch Vehicle on May 8, 2003 proves India can place a communications satellite into geosynchronous orbit after the first attempt in 2001.

10 Moon Magic 2008

India's space programme comes of age as the first un-manned space mission Chandrayaan-1 reaches the moon. It includes a lunar orbiter and an impactor launched by a modified version of the PSLV on October 22, 2008 and inserted into lunar orbit on November 8, 2008.

by Amarnath K. Menon



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